ENTREPRENEURIAL INNOVATION COURSE SYLLABUS

(MBA 570, WINTER 2026)

(January 14, 2026-Feb 26, 2026)

INSTRUCTOR, COURSE SCHEDULE, AND READING MATERIALS

Professor: Trent Williams, Ph.D.
E-mail: trentonwilliams@byu.edu[1]
Office Hours (TNRB 561): By appointment: https://calendly.com/trentonwilliams/nv-launchpad-check-in
Course Schedule:

Days: Tuesday and Thursday
Class session time (location):

Section 001: 9:30AM-10:45AM (W208)
Section 002: 12:30 PM – 1:45 PM (W210)

*A detailed schedule is on the last page and will be updated on Canvas. Please review Canvas as the most up-to-date source for class information

Required Reading Materials

There is no specific textbook for this class. I will provide readings that serve as the core material for the course that will be made available on Canvas. My objective is to reduce your expenses while maximizing the impact of content for purchase.

- **Course Content Available on Canvas:** This content includes articles, book chapters, and other materials. I have selected chapter sections from books that align with the HBLL content sharing policies.
- **Materials for Purchase**: I will post links for you to purchase materials (where relevant) on Canvas.

In addition to the required readings, I will also post optional, supplemental readings that can amplify your learning experience. I know that your time is limited as a full-time student. That said, this is a unique window of opportunity to learn as much as you can, and I would encourage you to take advantage of all the materials I share and suggest.

COURSE OVERVIEW

This course explores concepts of entrepreneurship and innovation that are essential for anyone involved in business. At the heart of this course are principles of creativity and curiosity, and how entrepreneurial innovation involves iterative often-winding processes for enacting positive changes. The structure of the course is to explore entrepreneurial innovation (EI) at expanding levels: individually, in teams/groups, within organizations, and in communities/society.

Recent years have revealed incredibly rigid-yet-false assumptions about who innovators are, how they achieve entrepreneurial breakthroughs, and ways to balance creative entrepreneurial exploration with efficient implementation/operation. We expose and challenge these assumptions through readings, cases, self-evaluations, and exercises. The course is designed to provide a foundation of core principles for those who might at some point want to launch their own organization, but it is especially focused on ways *you can become more creative, curious, and entrepreneurial* in existing organizations. Indeed, organizations must be entrepreneurial to compete and survive amidst increased globalization and tremendous market and technological change. Entrepreneurial innovation centers around people within established industries, markets, and/or organizations identifying, evaluating, and exploiting opportunities for new products, services, and business models. EI course explores the practices and challenges in initiating major product, service, or business model innovations.

The target learning outcomes and alignment with BYU and BYU-Marriott objectives are detailed on the final page of the syllabus.

[1] Email is the best method to contact me. I strive to respond to communications within 24 hours.

COURSE STRUCTURE AND PEDAGOGICAL APPROACH

Structure

The basic structure of the class is as follows. First, we examine individual-level aspects of EI, challenging assumptions about *who* innovators are and if/how *you* intend on cultivating and expanding your creative confidence. Second, we study where and how to identify and pursue innovative ideas. We identify different frameworks that are helpful in structuring these processes so you can run rapid experiments to explore, prototype, and test possible ideas. Third, we practice the ideas and processes through cases, mini-cases, and real-world scenarios. Finally, we close by exploring how you can apply these principles to your life, career, and professional journey.

Pedagogical approach

This course follows a **student-centered pedagogical approach**. We will use different methods including: cases (inquiry based learning, scaffolding pedagogy), pre-class readings and short-essays (flipped classroom and constructivism pedagogy), and guided workshops (experiential learning and scaffolding pedagogy).

*******This approach to learning only works if you come prepared for class*******

Failure to prepare for class will dramatically dampen the learning you receive. **Therefore, you have a decision to make—what are you willing to put into this class to extract its value?** I urge you to take advantage of the opportunity to experiment with and grow your creative capacity for entrepreneurial innovation. **Indeed, *few skills are in higher demand* than the ability to rapidly identify, pursue, and exploit entrepreneurial opportunities *within or outside of* an organization**. AI has only amplified the need for creatives capable of utilizing rapidly emerging/evolving tools to imagine, create, test, and iterate on transformative ideas.

CLASS ASSIGNMENTS AND ASSESSMENT

The assignments, exercises, and tasks for the class are all designed to have you *engage in the process of EI*. While simply *talking* about EI is somewhat useful, it is much better to learn-by-doing. I use a number of assessment tools to facilitate that process, which include both **Individual and Team** assignments.

One of my primary goals from this class is that you leave more confident in your capacity for entrepreneurial innovation, which includes experience with processes of leading innovative initiatives. Our assignments facilitate an ever-increasing level of engaging in that process including self-assessments, exploratory experiments (via cases), and engaging in the process more formally. The breakdown for assessment is detailed below:

Assessment Component	Points	% of Grade
Individual Assignments	**220**	**76%**
Participation and professionalism (mid-term)	30	
Participation and professionalism (end-term)	30	
Class preparation / individual assignments	160	
Team Assignments	**70**	**24%**
EI project proposal / outline	20	
EI project submission and presentation	50	
TOTAL	**290**	**100%**

Individual Assignments (76% of assessment)

Participation and professionalism—Posted for mid-term (0-30 points) and term end (0-30 pts)
A baseline expectation of this course is that you attend and participate. The ability to 'think on your feet,' constructively engage in a debate on class topics, and persuasively and succinctly articulate your point of view is critical for entrepreneurs, product managers and honestly for just about any profession and as a general life skill.

What I will be looking for in class discussions is the extent to which what you add to our discussions contributes to the learning of others in the class. If you are by nature a quiet person, please come talk to me and I'll help bring you into our class discussions. **Good comments possess one or more of the following attributes**:

- Relate to the topic at hand and/or integrate the topic with other course content.
- Are succinct and avoid hogging attention, time, or one's point of view (i.e., you acknowledge others in the conversation).
- Offer a different (sometimes contrarian), unique, and relevant perspective on the issue.
- Contribute to moving the discussion forward.
- Build on but don't repeat other comments (too often we fail to listen to the comments of others).
- Transcend the "I feel" syndrome; that is, they include some evidence or analysis of inherent tradeoffs. In other words, they demonstrate some reflective thinking.
- Offer solutions and /or possibilities *rather than* merely a critique. As the saying goes (in various forms)—"any idiot can tear down a barn, but it takes a carpenter to build one." Pointing out flaws, errors, and so forth is *easy* and not that interesting. Offering alternatives that can be critiqued takes effort, courage, and helps move our conversations forward.

Assessing participation (5 points each for 11 class sessions)
I will grade each student's contribution immediately following class and will post your score at mid and end of term (i.e., two scores ranging from 0-30 points). If you would like to know the status of your participation score, please come speak with me.

Absences, tardiness, and leaving early. Attendance is required for this course, so the absolute floor for participation and professionalism is showing up! **I allow 1 excused absence (for any reasons, so use it wisely) throughout the semester** as a general policy. If you have unique circumstances—please communicate those as early as possible. **Missing classes beyond the 1 excused absence will result in a 3% decrease in your final grade (e.g., 95% → 92% and so on)**. University approved absences and emergencies will be handled on a case-by-case basis. Again, just remember—use your one freebie wisely.

Showing up late and/or leaving early is disruptive to your fellow students, teams, and me. While I generally handle these issues on a case-by-case basis, if you are later than 5 minutes to class (without letting me know) and/or leave early (without alerting me to the situation) then you will be marked absent for the day.

Daily scoring for professionalism and participation. During each class I will make notes about participation. I will score participation in the following way:

- **You begin each session with a baseline score of 3 out of 5—that is for attending**. Your score can then go up or down depending on the professionalism and quality of your participation.
- **Factors decreasing your score**. Unprofessional conduct (i.e., demeaning others, hogging the conversation, etc.) and/or unproductive comments (i.e., simply re-stating someone's remarks to 'check the box') can result in your score going down from 3 to 2 or 1. Similarly, inappropriate use of technology (i.e., violating BYU-Marriott's phone policy; distracting yourself/others with off-topic computer usage, etc.) will decrease your score.
- **Factors increasing your score**. Professional and 'good comments' (see above) will result in an increase from the baseline 3 up to 4 or 5.

Please do not overly worry about getting a 'perfect' participation score. The goal is to *cultivate a community of learning* where *we engage the content together*, *integrate our understanding* with one another, *HAVE FUN*, and *take our learning to the next level*. Let's all commit to creating an environment for this to happen.

Class Preparation (110 pts) and Individual Assignments (50 pts) (160 total)

The books and course materials have been carefully selected to guide you through both the conceptual and practical steps of this course. The materials I have chosen meet two criteria: (1) they are extremely helpful and (2) they are incredibly interesting and easy to read. These are not textbooks that costs hundreds of dollars, they are interesting, research-backed materials that are directly applicable to your education and future career.

For our class to work, **you must come to class having done the reading**. I do not want to waste valuable in-class time re-hashing the reading or trying to explain baseline concepts you could get on your own time. To facilitate your success in achieving the learning outcomes, I reward you for doing the reading by giving simple 'short essay' assignments (11 total) that will be available on Canvas. In addition, I will have other assignments (totaling 50 points—see Canvas) that allow us to all be on the 'same page' when we begin class.

So could you use AI to just answer these questions? I mean, sure—but please think about what you are trading off *and* how you're wasting a key benefit if AI—it allows you to ask better questions and act more creatively. You're in school striving to gain new skills, competencies, and talents in your process of becoming. If you're simply here for a degree than it really doesn't matter what you learn. But if you want to become different then do the simple task of preparing by reading / watching / listening to the content, engaging the ideas, and then writing down your perspective. THAT'S IT! **Remember, it is by small and simple means that great things come to pass. Reading and responding to the material are some of those small, simple ways you can acquire, cultivate, and grow those valuable skills**.

Evaluation rubric: I will generally assess these assignments using a "completeness" rubric, looking for evidence that you engaged the readings, considered if/how it applies to you, and so forth.

Team Assignments (24% of assessment)

EI Proposal and Outline (20 pts)

About mid-way through the term we will workshop an "innovation challenge" in teams. This is to (a) practice the concepts we have been learning, and (b) give you experience mapping out and implementing and innovation project. In preparation for this workshop component of the class, you and your team will submit a proposal and outline using the template available on Canvas.

EI Project Submission and Presentation (50 pts)

Your team will provide a submission of your EI project (via Canvas) and then prepare a brief presentation. The scope, rubric, and criteria for this assignment are on Canvas.

Late work policy

Students are required to submit assignments by the deadlines specified in Canvas using the submission procedure specified for that assignment. If an assignment is not submitted on time, I will use the following criteria for point deductions prior to assessing the quality of the work. Why this approach? In real life, entrepreneurs *must* manage deadlines. Failure to do so can result in the loss of customers, disengagement of employees, and a multitude of negative firm outcomes.

Given that, if you miss a deadline (this happens!) I do want to give you an opportunity to claim *some* points if late—however there will be an escalating cost associated with the late submission. **If you have a critical conflict or life issue that precludes your submission of an assignment, *contact me ahead of time so we can work out a possible solution.* This too is consistent with the real world**. However, if you contact me days or weeks after missing assignments I will treat those situations differently, as that approach is unprofessional except in extremely rare circumstances.

Time Submitted	Percentage Decrease
All assignments (except quizzes)	
Late but same-day (i.e., was due at 9:00.00 but is turned in at 9:00.01)	20%
Late up to 24 hours post deadline	40%
Late more than 24 hours post deadline	60%

GRADING

This class is more about personal and professional development than it is about a letter grade. However, I realize grades are obviously very important to students. Therefore, the course is designed so that every member of the class has the opportunity to achieve any of the grades available. There are no tricks or hidden traps in any of the assessments. The work you put in, and the resultant quality you produce, will be the determining factors in the grade you receive. Just like the real world, if you are struggling or have concerns, it is your responsibility to resolve them using all your available resources. I am one of those resources, and I will do everything I can to help every single one of you be successful in this part of your development.

Grading Scale

Grade	Defined	Description	Percentage
A	Professional	Equal to Professional	>93%
A-	Excellent	Beyond expectations	90-93%
B+	Very Good	Exceeded some expectations	87-90%
B	Good	Met expectations	83-87%
B-	Average	Met some expectations	80-83%
C+-F	Poor - Pass	Below expectations	<80%

I do not engage in one-off grade revision negotiations. This policy is applied to all students to ensure your grade relative to your classmates will not change unfairly based on the grumblings of your classmates. If you have any questions, I highly recommend that you talk to me beforehand to ensure you are on the right track. If I do make a change to the policy, it will apply to all students in the class and will be announced.

DETERMINANTS OF SUCCESS

You Are in Charge—You get what you put in

You get what you invest. If you engage the readings, participate actively in class, and support a positive learning environment then this can be a very impactful class for you. But this is up to you to decide. I urge you to decide *now* how you can get the most of this narrow window in your life where you get to study, learn, and grow full time.

Ultimately, *you are responsible for your own learning.* You are also expected to monitor your own progress and keep track of your performance. **If you are having problems related to your understanding of the course material, expectations, and/or timeline then contact me immediately**. If in doubt, reach out. You can schedule a 1-on-1 with me via my calendar or exchange an email with me.

Communicate with me!

You have a unique window of time to pursue graduate studies here at BYU. However, at times 'life happens' and requires some flexibility. This happens in the real world as I am sure you know. **Therefore, I URGE you to communicate with me** if you are struggling, failing to keep up, and/or otherwise having problems that impede your work. **Please do not wait until you're at the cusp of failing to talk with me—speak with me early and often**. My goal is to match your energy and help you find solutions if there are life-challenges that threaten your personal wellbeing and/or academic success. This is not an empty offer; I encourage you to take me up on it!

COURSE POLICIES

This course adheres to the policies as detailed in the MBA policy manual. Please ensure you are familiar with those policies as they are relevant in this class. I highlight several course policies below. If I do not re-state BYU, BYU-Marriott, and/or the MBA policy that does not indicate it is irrelevant or inactive.

Extraordinary Circumstances

During the semester, some of you may experience unexpected and serious personal circumstances (e.g., prolonged illness, death of a family member, etc.). These circumstances may adversely affect your academic performance. ***I pledge to work with you during these times, but I must be informed immediately of any extraordinary situation that you think may be detrimental to your performance***. Any such conditions will not be considered in assigning grades if the information is not brought to my attention in a timely fashion.

Use of Student Work

Copies of student written work may be used for pedagogical purposes. An example of this would be using student assignments to illustrate what high-quality student work looks like. Any student work so used will be rendered anonymous through the removal of the name and other identifiers. Student work may also be used for teaching evaluation and assessment.

Honor Code

Being at BYU is a privilege for all of us who are here—faculty, staff, and students! As indicated in the MBA policy manual, "BYU exists to provide a university education in an atmosphere consistent with the ideals and principles of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. This atmosphere is preserved through commitment to conduct that reflects those ideals and principles. All students, staff, and faculty of BYU are expected to abide by the principles outlined in BYU Honor Code."

I do not view the honor code as a "morality police" document but rather a unified commitment to act professionally and respectfully as representatives of institutions bigger than ourselves: BYU, The Church of Jesus Christ, and our unifying membership in the BYU-Marriott community. I urge you to see this as an opportunity rather than a restrictive boundary.

Policy on Academic Integrity

Violation of the University Honor Code during any portion of this course will result in penalty up to and including failure of the course (depending on the nature of the conduct). I will strictly follow the University's Academic Misconduct guidelines. Please familiarize yourself with those policies found here.

Generative AI

Generative AI (GenAI) is an incredible resource and there will be ample opportunities to leverage it appropriately. Students are expected to follow university policies related to GenAI. Unless stated otherwise, you may use GenAI to support your learning and enhance your deliverables but not as a shortcut to avoid learning. **Cite any GenAI use with a footnote detailing the tool used and a brief description of how it was utilized**. I have specified when GenAI is prohibited for assignments. This policy aims to help you become the best professional possible by leveraging GenAI to *support your proactive development of critical skills* rather than to simply offload processes of becoming.

Disability-Related Accommodations

If any student will require assistance or academic accommodations for a disability, please contact me during my office hours, or by individual appointment. You must have established your eligibility for disability support services through the University Accessibility Center. You are also welcome to contact me privately to discuss your academic needs although I cannot arrange for disability-related accommodations.

COURSE SCHEDULE (SUBJECT TO CHANGE)

Class Schedule (T/Th)			Class Preparation and Assignments (due date)		
Week	**Date**	**Topic**	***Pre-class Reading****	***Assignment (date)*****	***In-class***
Week 1	Jan 13	Introduction	Read Syllabus (C) Bring your breakthrough ideas to life (C)	Pre-Class Survey (Jan 13) *(5 pts)* Class Prep (1) (Jan 13) *(10 pts)*	Intro/Overview
	Jan 15	What is EI? Challenging assumptions	Myths of Innovation (C) HIBT Podcast (C)	Class Prep (2) (Jan 15) *(10 pts)* Curiosity/Creativity Survey (Jan 18) *(5 pts)*	*Case discussion:* Myths and assumptions; Application to HIBT (audio cases)
Week 2	Jan 20	Cultivating EI (for me): Re-Thinking and Taking Action	Rethinking-Grant (C) Creative Confidence (C) How to Get Ideas (C)	Class Prep (3) (Jan 20) *(10 pts)* CC Growth Plan + Buglist (Jan 20) *(10 pts)*	*Workshopping*: Idea conditioning your mind; Cultivating CC
	Jan 22	Savannah Bananas Case	SB Case (P)	Class Prep (4) (Jan 22) *(10 pts)*	*Case discussion:* Contexts, stakeholders, and processes in EI
Week 3	Jan 27	Producing EI—Solving Need-based problems	Value Prop and JBTB (C) Needfinding (C) Minicase (C)	Class Prep (5) (Jan 27) *(10 pts)* JTBD & Value Prop (Jan 27) *(10 pts)*	*Workshopping:* Needfinding *Mini-case discussion*
	Jan 29	Addressing Needs Across the Stakeholder Value Chain	Case (C)	Class Prep (6) (Jan 29) *(10 pts)* Business Model Canvas (Jan 29) *(10 pts)*	Apply JTBD, Value Prop, Canvas *Failed innovations*
Week 4	Feb 3	Doing EI—Individuals, teams, and organizations	Design Sprint Process (C) Angel Studios Case (C) Scaling agile (C) *Optional*	Class Prep (7) *(10 pts)*	*Overview and workshopping innovation projects* *Overview of Angel Studios live case*
	Feb 5	DS (1): Mapping and Sketching	Power of questions (C) *Optional*	Class Prep (8) *(10 pts)* Team EI Proposal and Outline *(20 pts)*	*Angel Studios Case workshop*
Week 5	Feb 10	DS (2): Prototyping, failure, and deciding	Build to learn; Prototype (C)	Class Prep (9) *(10 pts)*	*Angel Studios Case workshop*
	Feb 12	DS (3): Testing and iterating	Mullins (C) *Optional*	Class Prep (10) *(10 pts)*	*Angel Studios Case workshop*
Week 6	Feb 17	*President's Day—Monday Classes*	How to pitch ideas (C) *Optional*	*Out of class work on presentations*	*NA*
	Feb 19	*Team EI Presentations*		Team presentations *(50 pts)*	*Angel Studios Case presentation*
Week 7	Feb 24	Innovating *your* future	Designing your life (C) *Revisit Curiosity / Innovation Scales and your CC Plans*	Class Prep (11) *(10 pts)* Reflection (Feb 24) *(10 pts)*	*Outro, reflection, and call to action*
	Feb 25	**WED FEB 25: END OF TERM 1**			

*Resource locations: C = Canvas; P = Purchase via link
**Assignment submissions are before class. See Canvas for assignment details and due dates

LEARNING OUTCOME GOALS

LEARNING OUTCOMES AND ALIGNMENT WITH BYU, BYU-MARRIOTT, AND PROGRAM GOALS

This course aims to support learning goals / Aims of BYU, the BYU-Marriott School and Entrepreneurship program. The greatest areas of focus will be:

A. **Creating new ideas, initiatives, processes, and/or ventures**: *A core aspect of EI is creating. We are made to create—to build, revise, expand, and grow. Acts of creation are foundational to our very nature are fundamental to a well-functioning society, community, and economy.* .
   - Links to BYU Aims: Think soundly, competence, communicate effectively, quantitative reasoning, lifelong learning, and global awareness.
   - Links to BYU-Marriott Vision, Mission, and Values (VMV): Integrity in action, excellence, respect for all, and faith in Jesus Christ to envision a better future.
   - Contributes Entrepreneurship Learning Outcomes (ELO): "Manage Uncertainty," "Innovate" and "Create New Businesses."

B. **Innovation**: *Innovation could be defined as enacting significant positive change. While broad, this is a fundamental skill BYU MBAs should leave with—an ability to enter a situation and then imagine and enact opportunities for positive change.*
   - Links to BYU Aims: Communicate effectively, think soundly, methodology expertise, and quantitative reasoning.
   - Links to BYU-Marriott VMV: Integrity in Action and Excellence
   - Contributes to ELOs: "Innovate"

C. **Communication Skills**: *Sell an idea and communicate effectively with stakeholders. This involves listening / learning to better see the needs of others, so that we can understand and take action together in making a situation better.*
   - Links to BYU Aims: Communicate effectively.
   - Links to BYU-Marriott VMV: Faith in Christ (Christlike leadership), Respect for All, and Integrity in Action.
   - Contributes to ELOs: "Create New Businesses"

D. **Utilizing data—quantitative and qualitative**: *Data represents information 'out there' that might help us better understand the needs of individuals, groups, organizations, communities, and society. We explore how to use data for different questions ranging from understanding braod contextual trends to isolating latent needs of a particular group. We link this with processes of identifying and creating opportunities, attracting customers (internal and external), and marketing new products/services.*
   - Links to BYU Aims: Quantitative reasoning and think soundly.
   - Links to BYU-Marriott VMV: Excellence and Integrity in Action
   - Contributes to ELOs: "Create New Businesses"

E. **Ethical Leadership**: *Manage EI processes ethically and serve as ethical leaders in the business community. A core tenet of EI involves empathy and understanding / fulfilling fundamental human needs. When done appropriately, EI ethically fulfills community needs rather than exploits them.*
   - Links to BYU Aims: Character building, spiritually strengthening, effective communication, and depth.
   - Links to BYU-Marriott VMV: Faith in Christ, Integrity in Action, Respect for All, and Excellence
   - Contributes to ELOs: "Manage Uncertainty"